

Microsoft 365 Copilot Analytics

Data Strategy

Entra ID vs. Org Data Upload — What to connect, why, and how to decide

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How This Document Fits

This is a **Strategy** guide. Read this to decide your data approach. Then hand off to IT with the Data Onboarding Guide for step-by-step implementation.

1. Why Upload Org Data? (Entra ID vs. Org Data Upload)

A common question: “We already have Department, Manager, and Organisation in Entra ID — why do we need to upload a CSV?”

Entra ID provides a baseline, but org data uploads unlock significantly more analytics capability:

Capability	Entra ID Only
Department filter on dashboard	Yes (Entra ID “Department” attribute)
Job Function / Job Discipline filter	No
Location filter	No
Level / Seniority filter	No
Custom attributes (Cost Centre, Agency, BU, Region)	No
Multi-agency / multi-BU partitioning	Yes — if each agency has a distinct email domain, use the system
Before/after cohort segmentation in Power BI	No segmentation
Manager hierarchy accuracy	Depends on Entra ID completeness
Data freshness control	Updated by directory team (often delayed)

TIP: When Entra ID Alone Is Sufficient

If you **only** need the Copilot Dashboard with tenant-level views and Department filtering — and the Entra ID Department attribute is accurate and consistently populated — you can skip the org data upload. However, if you need **any** of the following, org data upload is required: Location or Job Function filters, custom attributes (Cost Centre, Agency), or before/after cohort analysis in Power BI.

2. What Breaks with an Incomplete Entra ID Hierarchy?

If the Entra ID `Manager` attribute is missing or inconsistent for many users:

Feature	Impact
Auto CxO Identification	Fewer leaders are auto-identified. Users without a clear reporting line are
Manager Settings (team-level data)	Managers without a populated <code>Manager</code> attribute or without enough di
Filter by manager hierarchy (Publish Reports)	Published reports with “Filter by manager hierarchy” will show incomple
Advanced Analytics cohort segmentation	Manager-based grouping will be inaccurate.

Recommendation: If more than 20% of users lack a Manager attribute, prioritise fixing directory data or supplement with an org data CSV upload that includes correct `ManagerId` values.

3. Source Precedence Is Surface- and Attribute-Specific

An upload changes the source for the attributes supplied to the apps you select; it does **not** universally or permanently replace Microsoft Entra ID across Microsoft 365.

Surface / attribute	Controlling behaviour
Microsoft 365 User Profile	Microsoft Entra is the default source. Organizational Data in Microsoft 365
Copilot Dashboard and Viva Insights	Uploaded data shared with these apps supplies the mapped dashboard a
Viva ManagerId and Organization	Parallel ingestion can make Entra the default for either attribute, even whe
Uploaded optional and custom attributes	They remain upload/connector sourced unless an app has its own docum

Sources: Organizational Data in Microsoft 365 — Data precedence (Microsoft Learn, updated 2 December 2025); Manage settings for the Microsoft Copilot Dashboard, Agent Dashboard, and Viva Insights web app (20 March 2026); and Use Microsoft Entra plus .csv files for parallel data uploads (visible date 30 June 2025; page content refreshed 7 July 2026).

Supported correction and rollback paths

- **Update:** Upload only affected users and all attributes you intend to change. A blank value preserves the existing value because new uploads merge with previous data.
- **Delete a value:** Use the documented type-specific marker: two single quotes (' ') in CSV for strings (three in Excel), -1 for integers, a nonexistent in-tenant address for email values, or 01-01-0001 for dates.
- **Correct history:** Use **Historical import** with a CSV and a **File valid as of** date. Microsoft documents historical updates for Viva Insights data only.
- **Return ManagerId / Organization to Entra:** Enable those attributes under **Configure Entra connection**, then delete uploaded optional attributes you no longer need.
- **Migration failure:** Stop further imports and open a Microsoft support request. Microsoft documents temporary rollback only for critical migration issues in special cases.

Do Not Use a Dummy-Row Rollback

Do not use a one-row “Replace All” file as a general removal or rollback technique. It can leave an artificial hierarchy and break filters, partitions, or reports. Use the supported update/delete markers, parallel Entra restoration, or Microsoft Support instead.

Source: Import and manage your organizational data with a .csv file — Update or make other changes (Microsoft Learn, updated 2 April 2026), including retroactive updates; migration rollback is documented in Upload and maintain data through the Microsoft 365 admin center (5 December 2025).

4. Choose Your Upload Method

Start with “What HRIS do you use?” — not “how do I upload a CSV.”

Method	Who Manages	Status
SAP SuccessFactors Connector	Global Admin + SAP SF Admin	GA
Workday Connector	Global Admin + Workday Admin	Supported, up to 100,000 users
Azure Blob Storage	Global Admin + Data Engineer	Public Preview; Worldwide only
API-Based Import	Global Admin + Developer	Public Preview; Worldwide only
CSV Upload — M365 Admin Center	Org Data Source Administrator	GA
CSV Upload — Viva Insights web app	Insights Administrator	Official sources conflict; tenant-specific

Sources: Import organizational data from Workday (Microsoft Learn, updated 6 April 2026); Import organizational data using API-based import (preview) (6 April 2026); and Supported Microsoft 365 environments for Viva Insights features (30 June 2026).

NOTE: Decision Logic

- **Use SAP SuccessFactors or Workday** if your org runs either HRIS — eliminates manual CSV entirely
- **Consider Azure Blob Storage** for automated CSV drops from a data warehouse, subject to public-preview, cloud, and tenant availability
- **Consider API-based import** for programmatic integration or a custom HRIS, subject to public-preview, cloud, and tenant availability
- **Use CSV upload** for everything else — universal compatibility

TIP: Bypass On-Premises AD

If your HRIS data flows through **SAP SuccessFactors → middleware → on-premises AD → Entra ID**, be aware that Viva Insights only picks up 3 attributes from Entra (PersonId, ManagerId, Organization). Custom fields in Entra extensionAttributes are **not synced**.

Solution: Use the HRIS connector to send data directly to M365 — bypassing AD entirely for analytics purposes.

5. Data Planning Worksheet

Complete this before any upload. Share answers with your IT team when you hand off to the Data Onboarding Guide.

#	Question
1	Which HRIS does your organisation use? (SAP SF, Workday, Oracle, Custom, None)
2	Can your HRIS export a CSV with employee email, manager email, and department?
3	Which dashboard filters do you need beyond Department? (Job Function, Location, Level, Cost Centre, Agency, Regi
4	Do you need custom attributes for segmentation in Power BI reports? (e.g., Copilot Pilot Group, Hire Date, BU)
5	Who will own the monthly data refresh? (HR, IT, Data Engineering)
6	What does the latest Message Center migration notice say, and which add/edit controls are visible in the tenant UI?
7	Do multiple agencies share a single email domain? (If yes, you'll need a custom Agency attribute for partitioning)
8	Do you need to share org data with apps beyond Viva Insights? (M365 Profile, People Skills)

6. Determine the Current Tenant State

Official Microsoft Sources Conflict

Manage settings for the Microsoft Copilot Dashboard, Agent Dashboard, and Viva Insights web app (20 March 2026) still calls Viva web-app upload the recommended path for Viva Insights customers. Use Microsoft Entra plus .csv files for parallel data uploads (visible date 30 June 2025; refreshed 7 July 2026) says adding and editing uploads is no longer supported there. Upload and maintain data through the Microsoft 365 admin center (5 December 2025) says migration occurs in tenant-specific waves announced in Message Center.

Safest rule: Message Center and the actual tenant UI control the procedure. A calendar date or missing tile alone does not prove which path is supported.

Current-state gate

1. Read the latest tenant-specific Message Center post for organizational-data migration.
2. Open `admin.microsoft.com` → **Setup** → **Migration and imports** and record whether **Organizational Data in Microsoft 365** and its add/edit controls are available.
3. Open the Viva Insights web app and record whether organizational-data add/edit, delete, and Replace All controls are present. Do not assume all four move together.
4. Review existing connections so a second source is not introduced unintentionally.
5. If Message Center and the live UI agree, follow that path in the Data Onboarding Guide.
6. If they conflict, or neither surface offers a supported add/edit path, **stop**. Capture the Message Center post ID/date, screenshots, roles, tenant cloud, and existing connection status; then escalate through Microsoft Support or the account team before uploading.

7. What to Read Next

Ready to...	Read this
Upload data (step-by-step)	Data Onboarding Guide (Setup layer)
See the full attribute mapping table	Attribute Reference (Reference layer)
Troubleshoot a failed upload	Troubleshooting Guide (Reference layer)
Understand multi-agency data isolation	Multi-Agency Decision Guide (Strategy layer)

Disclaimer

This guide is provided as a procedural reference. Always refer to Organizational Data in Microsoft 365 on Microsoft Learn for the most up-to-date information.